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Analysing the Impact of Macroeconomic Indicators On Fashion Retail Sales in the UK

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DECLARATION

I, Lala Bigvava, declare that I am the sole author of this Project; that all references cited have been consulted; that I have conducted all work of which this is a record, and that the finished work lies within the prescribed word limits.

This has not previously been accepted as part of any other degree submission.

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Abstract

This dissertation examines how key macroeconomic indicators influence the financial performance of the UK fashion retail sector by analysing three representative brands: Primark (fast fashion), Burberry (luxury), and Nobody's Child (sustainable fashion). Company-level financial data were combined with macroeconomic series, including GDP, inflation (CPIH Clothing and Footwear), unemployment, interest rates, and sector-wide retail sales from 2010 to 2024.

A quantitative, descriptive framework was employed using time-series visualisation, scatter plots, and Pearson correlation analysis. The process was carried out in Python to ensure transparency, reproducibility, and robust data handling.

Findings indicate that GDP growth and sector-wide retail sales have the strongest positive influence across all three brands, emphasising the sector's reliance on macroeconomic expansion and consumer demand. Unemployment consistently shows a negative relationship, especially for Primark, reflecting the impact of consumer confidence on mass-market spending. Burberry exhibits greater sensitivity to global cycles and individual spending patterns, whilst Nobody's Child, as a younger ethical brand, closely follows growth phases but remains susceptible to financial stress.

The study advances the literature by offering a firm-level, segment-specific analysis of fashion retailers under macroeconomic pressure. It highlights how market positioning affects resilience and provides insights for both academics and practitioners seeking to understand the intersection of macroeconomic dynamics and brand strategy.

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Chapter 1: Introduction

1.1Background and Motivation

The fashion retail sector is also a significant component of the UK economy, as it contributes billions of pounds annually to consumer spending, employment, and national output (BFTT, 2021). It has an impact on international trade, supply chains, and logistics in addition to retail operations. This influence stems from its calculated economic importance. This changing nature defines the field. Important susceptibility exists, too. Household purchasing power, credit conditions, and consumer confidence are influenced by macroeconomic variables such as GDP growth, inflation, unemployment, and shifts in monetary policy, which in turn shape demand within the industry (ONS, 2021).

The industry has been able to handle all the problems. Over the past two decades, these events have significantly reshaped the sector's landscape. Following the global financial crisis of 2008, there were big shifts in what people spent their money on. Retailers were then forced to adjust their business strategies. Brexit complicated trade through disruptions to supply chains and an increase in operational costs, whereas the COVID-19 epidemic disrupted demand and increased the use of digital channels (BFTT, 2023). Lately, sustained inflationary pressures have driven a cost-of-living crisis, resulting in reduced disposable incomes, altered consumption behaviours, and expanded competition (ONS, 2022). These economic shifts underscore the pressing need to understand how macroeconomic conditions influence retail performance. It is also important for one to understand their impact, which varies by market segments.

This dissertation tactically examines three distinct brands —Primark, Burberry, and Nobody's Child —to explore how macroeconomic dynamics perform in the fast-fashion, luxury, and sustainable fashion segments.

- Primark is a prominent fast-fashion seller. It competes through its affordability and its high-volume turnover. Studies indicate that value is often key for consumers who are sensitive to prices, despite rising awareness of environmental impact. Economic conditions, therefore, play a critical role in driving demand in this segment.

- Burberry is a heritage luxury brand that has innovated digitally and maintained strong brand equity so that it can be resilient during economic downturns. Its noble position and global reach protect it from price increases that negatively impact mass-market shops.
- Nobody's Child, a sustainable brand emerging now, represents a niche based in the UK driven by consumers aware. Positioning calculations for this brand provide valuable insights into the evolving demand for ethical fashion and economic conditions, although the data is limited.

This research aims to provide a nuanced, data-driven understanding of how economic cycles, inflationary trends, and structural shifts may impact different segments within the fashion retail sector by integrating company-level financial data with key macroeconomic indicators. The results aim to foster perceptions of academic relevance among industry professionals and policymakers. These perceptions are a valuable tool for navigating a complex retail environment.

1.2Research Aim and Objectives

This study primarily aims to examine the relationship between the financial results of UK fashion retailers and key macroeconomic factors, including GDP, inflation, unemployment, and interest rates. The research examines how shifts in the economic environment impact the performance of brands. Primark, Burberry, and Nobody's Child represent fast-fashion, luxury, and sustainable brands, respectively, through integrating company-level financial data with macroeconomic trends.

Objectives:

- To develop a comprehensive and reproducible database by systematically collecting and organising publicly available datasets on key macroeconomic indicators and company-level financial data for Primark, Burberry, and Nobody's Child.

- To integrate, clean, and transform these datasets to ensure temporal consistency and Accurate alignment between macroeconomic and firm-level variables, thereby enabling accurate comparative and long-term analyses.
- To examine and evaluate the relationships between macroeconomic indicators and company financial performance using correlation testing, descriptive statistics, and exploratory statistical models.
- To analyse and compare the sensitivity and resilience of the three brands — Primark (fast fashion), Burberry (luxury fashion), and Nobody's Child (sustainable fashion) — to macroeconomic shifts and external shocks, including Brexit and the COVID-19 pandemic.
- To clarify and synthesise the findings within the context of existing literature, generating theoretical insights and actionable recommendations for retailers, policymakers, and investors, while identifying limitations and opportunities for future research.

1.3 Research Questions

To guide the investigation, the following research questions frame this study.

- RQ1: How do macroeconomic indicators such as GDP, inflation, unemployment, and interest rates affect the financial performance of UK fashion retailers?
- RQ2: Do differing relationships appear across fast-fashion, luxury, and sustainable segments within Primark, Burberry, and Nobody's Child?
- RQ3: How did major external shocks influence the relationship between macroeconomic conditions with brand performance? Brexit plus the COVID-19 pandemic are examples of those shocks.

1.4Success Criteria

The success of this project success in its ability to produce tangible outcomes. These results must be sound in method and relevant to practice. The key criteria include:

- Integrating firm-level financials with relevant macroeconomic indicators to create a clean, reproducible dataset across the study period.
- Descriptive analyses plus clear visualisations are made to show patterns, trends, and correlations across economic indicators and companies.
- Perceptive and comparative findings are provided here that highlight similarities and differences in how fast-fashion, luxury, and sustainable brands respond to macroeconomic changes.
- A transparent and reproducible workflow is being offered here, and Python coding with data preparation steps is quite clearly documented for later validation and for future research.
- Findings such as those that can inform the planned decision-making process for retailers, along with policy discussions specifically in the UK fashion sector, may contribute both to academic discourse and to industry practice.

1.5 Project Risks and Ethical Considerations

Several possible dangers and challenges face this project.

- Financial data for newer firms, such as Nobody's Child, may be limited. Thus, the longitudinal analysis depth is limited, and the reliability of statistical perception for this segment decreases.
- Data consistency issues: Differing financial reporting standards as well as fiscal-year calendars could challenge alignment when firms integrate level and macroeconomic data.
- Scope adjustments: Researchers did exclude certain macroeconomic indicators that were initially considered (e.g., less relevant inflation indices or unrelated financial metrics) to focus analytically as well as prevent noise within the dataset.

The research utilises only secondary data from reliable, publicly available sources. These sources, from such an ethical perspective, do include the Office for National Statistics, the

Bank of England, and some company reports. Processing for confidential or sensitive data is not ensured.

To uphold academic integrity:

- The entire workflow is transparent and reproducible, with Python code and data preparation steps fully documented.
- All data and literature sources are accurately referenced in Harvard style, avoiding any risk of misrepresentation or selective reporting.
- Analytical outputs are presented objectively, with clear acknowledgement of limitations to prevent overinterpretation of results.

1.6 Project Roadmap and Structure of the Thesis

This thesis ensures clarity plus coherence through a logical, structured progression from data preparation to results interpretation.

Chapter 2: Literature Review- synthesises both academic and industry research that is on analytical approaches, sector-specific challenges, and macroeconomic influences that are in retail.

Chapter 3: Methodology- The study details the research design, data sources, methods for preparation, and analysis strategy.

Chapter 4: Data Analysis and Key Findings- describes the integrated dataset and the cleaning and transformation steps, and it provides initial descriptive analyses and visualisations.

Chapter 5: Model Implementation- explains the statistical as well as econometric models for evaluating company performance and macroeconomic indicators' relationships.

Chapter 6: Discussion and Interpretation of Findings- presents as well as interprets each of the findings. It also highlights company-specific perceptions and cross-segment comparisons.

Chapter 7: Conclusion and Recommendations- gives a summary of the study's key points, with a discussion of practical effects on industry and policy. The summary outlines limitations and suggests avenues toward research.

This structure provides a clear narrative flow, transitioning from contextual understanding to practical perceptions through analysis, making the research accessible and actionable for both academic and industry audiences.

Chapter 2: Literature Review

2.1 Introduction

The UK fashion retail sector brings together economic, political, and social forces. Thus, changes in the macroeconomic environment significantly impact it. Household purchasing power, along with consumer behaviour, is shaped by indicators such as GDP growth, inflation, unemployment, and disposable income, as policy decisions, structural reforms, and global events introduce additional layers of complexity (ONS, 2021).

This sector navigated through a series of deep disruptions. The navigation occurred over the past two decades. The 2008 global financial crisis reshaped consumer demand and squeezed profit margins, and the UK's withdrawal from the European Union (Brexit) introduced regulatory uncertainty. The COVID-19 pandemic triggered remarkable operational and demand shocks, along with some supply chain disruption. Trends reshaping competitive dynamics across fast fashion, luxury, and emerging ethical segments (BFTT, 2023) coexist with these shocks, including digital transformation, evolving consumer preferences, and the growing importance of sustainability.

This chapter reviews academic studies and industry reports to provide a solid foundation for this research. It examines:

- the relationship between macroeconomic indicators and retail performance.
- the effects of Brexit and trade policy uncertainty.

- structural shifts triggered by COVID-19 and the post-pandemic retail landscape.
- the role of tourism in shaping retail sales, particularly in the luxury segment.
- the influence of sustainability and innovation on competitiveness; and
- the impact of macroeconomic volatility on global value chains.

The chapter identifies key knowledge gaps via synthesising these categories of literature, as well as especially the lack of firm-level, segment-specific evidence. This study addresses these gaps through a data-driven comparative analysis of three representative brands, namely Primark, Burberry, and Nobody's Child.

2.2 Macroeconomic Indicators and Retail Sales

Macroeconomic conditions are closely tied to the performance of the UK fashion retail sector. GDP growth, inflation, unemployment, and consumer confidence drive retail turnover because they directly influence household spending and discretionary purchasing patterns (ONS, 2021).

Recent studies support integrating external economic variables into retail performance analysis. The accuracy of retail sales forecasts can be improved through the integration of advanced predictive models with external signals, such as macroeconomic indicators and consumer behaviour trends (Corallo et al., 2024). Their findings underscore the true value that data-driven frameworks possess, as these frameworks capture both cyclical and structural market dynamics. Econometric models are applied to evaluate the relationship between macroeconomic conditions and fashion retail performance across sustainable, luxury, and fast fashion segments, providing support for the methodological foundation of this dissertation.

Steady economic growth, accompanied by rising disposable income, is reflected in historical data, which show that total retail volumes more than doubled between 1989 and 2021 (ONS, 2021). However, sharp contractions during economic downturns have repeatedly interrupted this upward trend. For instance, the 2008 global financial crisis significantly declined apparel

sales, and the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020 resulted in a record sharp reduction in non-essential shopping, as lockdowns shuttered stores nationwide (ONS, 2021).

Inflation was especially influential. This influence has been seen in recent years. A 1% inflation increase typically lowers clothing sales volumes by about 0.4%, according to the Institute of Business Trends (IBT, 2023) data, as it reflects many consumers' price sensitivity. GDP growth has a positive elasticity of approximately 0.6. Periods of expansion stimulate increased demand for fashion retail (IBT, 2023). Unemployment also matters greatly because joblessness rises 1% and apparel revenues decline 0.5%, signalling that consumer confidence and financial security shape discretionary spending.

Sector cycles become stressed through these dynamics, making macroeconomic stability a paramount concern. This dependence provides us with a critical framework for the brand-level analysis undertaken in this study.

2.3 Brexit and Trade Policy Uncertainty

Brexit deeply shocked the UK fashion retail industry structurally more than anything else in recent decades. Fashion retail, being a sector characterised by complex global value chains and narrow operating margins, has been particularly exposed to the operational and financial pressures created by the UK's withdrawal from the EU (Casadei and Iammarino, 2021).

Research highlights that it was in the immediate aftermath of the referendum that common uncertainty triggered, currency volatility occurred, and supply chains were disrupted (Casadei and Iammarino, 2021). Brexit has imposed approximately £7 billion in additional customs costs, while causing shipping delays of up to 21 days for goods moving between the UK and EU markets, according to the Business of Fashion, Textiles and Technology (BFTT, 2023). SMEs found these disruptions especially challenging. They comprise more than 80% of the UK fashion ecosystem because they often lack the resources to absorb such shocks.

Big brands felt impacts that mattered too. These effects were equally important to them. Burberry experienced margin erosion due to currency fluctuations and increased export issues in major European markets (BFTT, 2023). Operating on a low-cost and high-volume model,

Primark maintained its competitive pricing strategy without compromising on costs to offset rising logistics and tariff expenses (BFTT, 2023).

Many firms have reassessed sourcing strategies, diversified supplier networks, and invested in digital supply chain capabilities to build resilience against active uncertainty (Johnsson and Kramer, 2023). By these adjustments, the long-term implications of Brexit are highlighted, showing how macroeconomic and policy shocks reshape competitive and operational landscapes, rather than just affecting performance in the short term.

2.4 COVID-19 and the Post-Pandemic Retail Landscape

The COVID-19 pandemic dealt an unprecedented shock to the UK fashion retail sector, as it disrupted demand, operations, and supply chains on a scale unmatched in modern history. Clothing and footwear sales volumes in 2020 declined by over 25%, marking the steepest annual decline on record (ONS, 2021).

Store-based retailers such as Primark experienced excessive effects. Since there was no online sales channel that could offset losses, Primark faced estimated monthly revenue declines of £650 million during lockdown closures (BFTT, 2023). Burberry's digital infrastructure enabled the brand to shift quickly as an alternative, as it expanded its e-commerce offerings and implemented digital interaction strategies to maintain customer attention (BFTT, 2023).

Emerging brands such as Nobody's Child leveraged during this period to strengthen their digital presence. They also worked toward building deeper connections with consumers. Ethical consumers were drawn to the brand using value-driven marketing and social media collaborations. This move set up the brand to grow despite industry decline (BFTT, 2021).

Also, the pandemic exposed global supply chains beyond their limits. Many retailers responded by diversifying suppliers through nearshoring production. They invested in digital visibility tools to improve resilience (World Economic Forum, 2021).

The pandemic has caused structural changes, including faster technology use and changes in what consumers anticipate, in addition to short-term disruptions. Today, consumers engage more digitally, are conscious in terms of value, and attune themselves to that of sustainability,

which forces retailers to then embed agility and innovate within their operational and calculated models (IBT, 2023).

2.5 Tourism and the Fashion Economy

UK fashion retail has historically been driven by tourism, especially within luxury retail. London has long been recognised as one of the world's premier shopping destinations, as 57% of inbound visitors engage in shopping activities (VisitBritain, 2015). International tourists from Asia, the Middle East, and North America generated high-value transactions for luxury retailers, such as Burberry (BFTT, 2023).

Currency fluctuations have intensified this dynamic, as periods of sterling weakness make UK luxury goods more attractive to overseas buyers (Casadei and Iammarino, 2021). However, the COVID-19 pandemic unexpectedly stopped international travel, as it eliminated a significant source of revenue. Luxury retailers needed to pivot toward domestic markets and needed to engage consumers to offset those losses digitally. Burberry transformed its digital presence in a faster manner as it focused more closely on domestic consumer relationships (BFTT, 2023).

Although tourism is recovering, the rebound is uneven, and luxury retailers are also vulnerable to continuing economic volatility and shifting travel patterns (IBT, 2023). This evolving landscape highlights the importance of diversifying both geographically and operationally to reduce reliance on global mobility and sustain growth within the luxury segment.

2.6 Sustainability and Innovation in the Fashion Sector

Sustainability has shifted from being considered a peripheral concern to being a major support in strategic planning and deciding upon operations in the UK fashion industry. As consumer awareness increases, regulatory frameworks tighten, and global environmental pressures mount, retailers are pushed to integrate sustainable practices throughout their value chains (BFTT, 2021). This shift is evident across market segments, from emerging ethical brands to

established global leaders. For competitiveness now, sustainability is mandatory, which signals it is no longer a Strategic advantage.

This transition serves as Nobody's Child. The company aligned its brand identity with ethical production and transparent supply chains, in addition to partnering with retailers like Marks & Spencer and ASOS. The company then capitalised on the increased demand for sustainable fashion and reported a 35% year-over-year sales increase in 2022 (BFTT, 2023). Consumer interest, as argued by Forsman and Madsen (2017), does not always yield consistent purchasing behaviour. Labelling for sustainability is confusing to people, and there is scepticism about greenwashing, as well as price sensitivity. Often, these factors generate a divide between buying patterns and consumer intentions. Brands like Nobody's Child face active challenges from this tension, balancing authenticity, transparency, and affordability to maintain growth momentum.

A complex paradox is now faced by fast-fashion giants like Primark. Sustainable initiatives made progress, including the growth of recycled material use and the implementation of supply-chain transparency programs. Their high-volume, low-cost model remains subject to scrutiny, however (IBT, 2023), in times when the economy is uncertain, consumers frequently decide that affordability outweighs any ethical considerations as well (BFTT, 2021). When ethical issues are considered, consumers make this decision. These dynamics stress structural problems when firms reconcile scale-driven models with sustainability demands, which shows operational strategies must be transformative, not progressively changed.

Innovation changes the structure of how people operationalise sustainability beyond consumer behaviour. Brands are being enabled to reduce waste and to improve efficiency as well as provide valid proof of ethical practices through advances within fabric recycling, together with biodegradable textiles using digital tracking technologies systems (Johnsson and Kramer, 2023). Burberry, as an example, has included circular economy initiatives into its operations because it combines material innovation with high-end design to align sustainability with its luxury brand positioning (BFTT, 2023).

People must act responsibly plus collaborate systemically to progress meaningfully, Moorhouse (2020) argues. For adopting closed-loop systems and circular models, individual actors cannot rely alone but must involve actors cooperating across the supply chain, from

manufacturers and designers to retailers and consumers. Ethical brands like Nobody's Child see that they must increase circular plans and communicate openly to create lasting strength plus customer faith.

The results are like Joy et al. (2012) since who studied the cultural and social forces sustaining ethical consumption. Their research suggests that it is the appeal of both sustainable and luxury brands which is often closely linked to identity formation and status signalling, and this also offers deeper perception into the behavioural drivers that shape consumer engagement with sustainability in the fashion sector. Brands that successfully balance authenticity, accessibility, and a sense of value thrive in today's fast-changing market, which is driven by the powerful connection between ethics, identity, and social perception.

2.7 Macroeconomic Factors and Value Chain Reconfiguration

Macroeconomic fluctuations have exposed the UK fashion industry to the linked nature of global value chains. Brexit, the COVID-19 pandemic, increasing energy costs, also geopolitical tensions are events that have revealed supply chain vulnerabilities. These supply chains were optimised mainly for cost efficiency as opposed to resilience (Johnsson and Kramer, 2023). Companies are reconsidering their planned objectives since these delays have translated into longer delivery schedules. Additionally, elevated logistics costs and operational uncertainty are consequences of these disruptions.

Many retailers have adopted resilience-oriented approaches. These actions serve to involve nearshoring production to reduce dependence on global transport networks, along with diversifying supplier bases to lower the risk of regional shocks. They also invest in digital supply chain management systems for transparency and agility (IBT, 2023). Such strategies do allow brands to manage disruptions. Brands can also respond more dynamically to shifts in demand under cost pressures. Burberry, for instance, utilises real-time digital monitoring tools to enhance logistics oversight and inventory planning. At the same time, Primark fosters supplier relationships to improve operational flexibility without compromising its low-cost model (BFTT, 2023).

Research emerges suggesting that integrating advanced analytics within these strategies offers a meaningful competitive advantage. Corallo et al. (2024) show that predictive models, with the incorporation of macroeconomic and behavioural data, can improve demand forecasting and inventory optimisation and enable firms to anticipate shocks and adapt more effectively. This evidence goes to show that data-driven perceptions are of importance. They help to build value chains that are both strong and adaptive to sustain operational performance within volatile economic environments. Companies that use these skills can better handle external issues in addition to changing uncertainty into planned agility that increases their lasting competition.

2.8 Research Gaps and Contribution of This Study

The literature gives some valuable perceptions into all the macroeconomic dynamics within the UK fashion retail sector. However, some of the critical gaps remain to be addressed.

First, a lot of the current research adopts an aggregate perspective, and it focuses on overall retail sales or on broad macroeconomic trends (IBT, 2023). This approach overlooks how different market segments uniquely feel since fast fashion, luxury, and sustainable brands respond differently to economic shocks, given that business models, consumer bases, and operational strategies differ (BFTT, 2023).

Second, few studies have systematically integrated Brexit and COVID-19 into empirical analyses (Casadei and Iammarino, 2021), although both have been widely discussed. Due to these disruptions, the relationships between macroeconomic indicators and brand performance are limited.

Much of the available evidence remains within the domain of grey literature. Furthermore, this is evidence that is regarding brand-level sustainability performance. For example, independent evaluators, such as the Curiously Conscious (2024) audit of Nobody's Child, offer valuable transparency through their listing of factories, breakdown of materials, and exclusion of high-impact inputs. However, they lack the depth and standardisation found in third-party verified reporting. This highlights a broader research gap due to the absence of consistent,

independently audited metrics for sustainability performance across brands. The lack of these metrics complicates comparative academic analysis and limits the ability to evaluate the true depth of sustainable transformation across the sector.

Firm-level studies that combine financial performance data with macroeconomic variables across a significant time horizon remain data-driven (Johnsson and Kramer, 2023). This divide makes it harder for policymakers, academics, and practitioners to build solid evidence-based strategies.

This study fills these voids because it:

- Integrating firm-level and macroeconomic data from 2010 and 2024 for three brands: Primark, Burberry, and Nobody's Child.
- Each segment has sensitivities that apply to key indicators, such as GDP, inflation, unemployment, and retail demand. The quantification of these sensitivities is important.
- Assessing just how shocks reshaped retail dynamics via testing regarding structural disruptions associated with Brexit and COVID-19.

The research, in fact, adopts this approach to offer a subtle comparative perspective. It also provides a bridge between academic inquiry and practical application. It does contribute a reproducible dataset for those scholars. Future studies can benefit from a strong methodological framework. For practitioners and policymakers, it provides actionable insights into how macroeconomic volatility interacts with brand-specific dynamics, enabling them to make more informed decisions in strategy, policy, and operations.

Chapter 3: Methodology

3.1 Introduction

This chapter outlines the methodology employed by researchers to investigate how key macroeconomic indicators impacted the financial performance of selected UK fashion retailers. To analyse patterns, relationships, and structural shifts over time, the study adopts

a quantitative, data-driven design that integrates company-level financial metrics with macroeconomic datasets.

This methodology is deliberately strict, reproducible, and transparent, ensuring that the findings withstand both academic scrutiny and practical application. The research employs a comparative framework, complemented by an exploratory descriptive analysis. It seeks to view and then explain trends in past data, rather than making guesses or projections. This approach enables a nuanced understanding of how macroeconomic dynamics may have coincided with changes in brand performance. This method does not overstate causality.

3.2 Research Design

The study employs a quantitative, longitudinal, and comparative framework, utilising secondary data spanning the period from 2010 to 2024.

- Financial performance at the company level and relationships between macroeconomic variables can be measured using a quantitative approach. Concerning macroeconomic variables, these include interest rates, unemployment, inflation, and GDP.
- Cyclical trends and external shocks are captured by the longitudinal dimension, like Brexit (2016), the COVID-19 pandemic (2020, 2021), and the Bank of England's interest rate hikes (2022), so the analysis can incorporate cyclical and structural shifts (ONS, 2021; BFTT, 2023).
- The comparative element examines how Primark (fast fashion), Burberry (luxury), and Nobody's Child (sustainable fashion) differ tactically as brands in action. This enables an exploration into how differences in market positioning, consumer base, and operational models shape the sensitivity plus resilience of those firms to economic pressures.

The research offers valuable insights to academic practitioners and policymakers through a combination of factors and sound educational methods.

3.3 Data Sources

3.3.1 Macroeconomic Data

The study draws on datasets from the Bank of England (BoE) and the Office for National Statistics (ONS) to capture the broader economic environment. The key indicators include:

- GDP – Annual UK economic output (ONS, 2024)
- CPIH (Clothing and Footwear Index) – Inflation trends within the apparel sector (ONS, 2024)
- Unemployment Rate – Rolling three-month averages as a proxy for consumer confidence (ONS, 2024)
- Bank Rate – The Bank of England's base rate to track monetary policy shifts (BoE, 2024)
- Retail Sales Index for Textiles, Clothing, and Footwear (TCF) – Sector-specific retail demand trends (ONS, 2024)

These macroeconomic conditions together shape a strong view about the UK fashion sector's performance.

3.3.2 Company-Level Data

Data at the firm level were collected for each of the three case-study brands to ensure that financial performance aligned with economic trends:

- **Primark** – Turnover and operational data from Associated British Foods' annual reports.
- **Burberry** – Revenue, sales growth, and operational metrics from Burberry Group plc annual reports.

- **Nobody's Child** – Financial data from Companies House, supplemented by industry insights from platforms such as Statista and McKinsey (2024).

This method, drawing on multiple sources, ensures a reliable and thorough dataset to assess how each retailer aligns with shifts in the economy.

3.4 Data Preparation

A few organised actions were needed for building a neat, unified panel dataset. Accuracy and comparability were ensured through these steps.

- Frequencies happen to be harmonised since all the data had been standardised to just an annual format for the purpose of aligning company performance metrics with different macroeconomic indicators.
- Company financial years were adjusted so that temporal comparisons through fiscal period alignment would be consistent, reflecting the relevant calendar year.
- The clothes and footwear component of the CPIH index was used to reduce turnover statistics for inflation. This converts the nominal figures into real terms for enabling meaningful comparisons across time.
- Growth rate calculations, Year-on-year percentage changes were calculated for both company-level and macroeconomic indicators because the goal was to reveal patterns of sharp expansion or contraction.
- Scaling as well as transformations, Turnover values were expressed in terms of millions of pounds for consistency. Variance stabilisation, along with elasticity-based interpretation, was supported through logarithmic transformations where appropriate.

The resulting dataset was both clean and harmonised. It provided, as a result, a strong foundation for descriptive and correlation-based analyses.

3.5 Analytical Strategy

This study employs a descriptive, exploratory, and analytical framework, designed to identify patterns relating macroeconomic indicators to the financial performance of Primark, Burberry, and Nobody's Child. The analysis began with a descriptive exploration and then moved to a visual relationship analysis. The study concluded with correlation testing. This systematic method combined visual narratives with statistical proofs, providing a data-driven view that was integrated while avoiding causal or predictive excess.

3.5.1 Descriptive Exploration

Time-series visualisations were first employed to map the trajectories of company performance indices against key macroeconomic indicators, including GDP, unemployment, interest rates, retail sales, and sector-specific inflation. These plots provided an initial, high-level view of long-term dynamics and allowed the study to identify where major structural events — such as Brexit, the COVID-19 pandemic, and the subsequent post-pandemic recovery — appeared to coincide with shifts in performance.

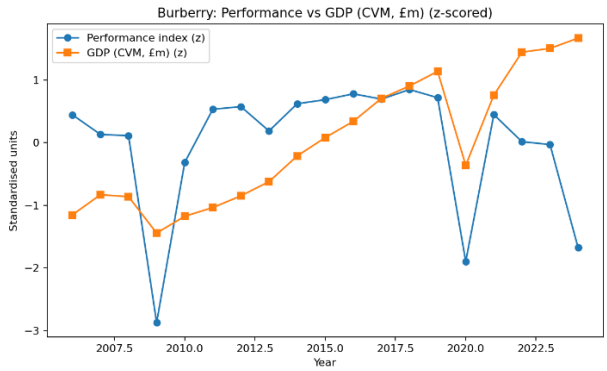


Figure a 3.1 Burberry performance index vs. Bank Rate (2006–2025), z-scored.

The purpose of this stage was not to draw conclusions but to build familiarity with the dataset and to highlight possible relationships worthy of closer inspection. For example, as illustrated in Figure 3.1, time-series charts enabled comparisons between brand performance and GDP

across the study period, offering a way to see whether patterns of growth and contraction aligned with wider economic cycles. This stage of exploration was therefore essential in setting the foundation for more focused relationship analysis.

3.5.2 Visual Relationship Analysis

The second stage of analysis employed scatter plots to examine the relationships between brand performance and individual macroeconomic indicators in greater detail. These visualisations were especially useful for identifying the direction and strength of associations more directly than time-series charts alone.

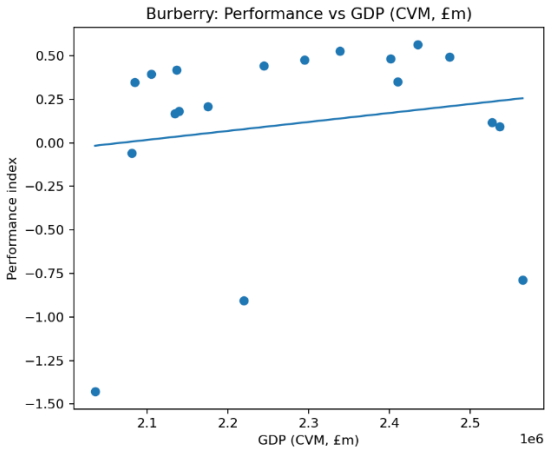


Figure b 3.2 Scatter plot of Burberry performance index vs. GDP (2006–2025).

For instance, scatter plots such as Figure 3.2 allowed the study to test visually whether higher levels of economic output were generally associated with stronger company turnover, while also revealing the degree of variation around these trends. Similarly, scatter plots contrasting unemployment rates and performance indices made it possible to see how consumer confidence might influence brand resilience during periods of economic stress.

By combining these descriptive and relational visuals, the methodology established a clear analytical pathway: from broad exploration of patterns to more targeted visual testing of

potential relationships. The specific findings from these visual analyses are presented in detail in Chapter 6 (Results and Analysis).

3.5.3 Correlation Analysis

Finally, Pearson correlation coefficients were calculated to quantify the observed strength and direction of the relationships. These statistical results validated the patterns seen visually, confirming that the descriptive analysis was robust.

macro_variable	corr_with_perf_index	brand
gdp_millions_cvm	0.528802796	Burberry
unemployment_rate	-0.623847138	Burberry
bank_rate_eoy	0.226063883	Burberry
cpih_clothing_index_avg	0.447093406	Burberry
retail_tcf_avg_weekly_thou	0.408941062	Burberry
gdp_millions_cvm	0.794001439	Nobody's Child
unemployment_rate	-0.468585602	Nobody's Child
bank_rate_eoy	0.632637286	Nobody's Child
cpih_clothing_index_avg	0.588551851	Nobody's Child
retail_tcf_avg_weekly_thou	0.488182091	Nobody's Child
gdp_millions_cvm	0.593096311	Primark
unemployment_rate	-0.760486787	Primark
bank_rate_eoy	-0.083378634	Primark
cpih_clothing_index_avg	0.229553885	Primark
retail_tcf_avg_weekly_thou	0.421841158	Primark

Figure 3.2 Correlation with performance index

- Burberry: Turnover showed a moderately strong positive correlation with GDP (r = 0.53). Unemployment was strongly negative (r = -0.62), underscoring the sensitivity of luxury purchases to shifts in consumer confidence.
- Primark: GDP was positively associated (r = 0.59), and retail sales within the clothing and footwear sector also showed a positive link (r = 0.42). Unemployment carried the strongest negative effect (r = -0.76), although the brand's value-driven positioning suggests resilience compared to luxury segments.
- Nobody's Child: GDP (r = 0.79) and retail sales (r = 0.49) both exhibited strong positive associations, while unemployment was moderately negative (r = -0.47). These patterns reflect how favourable economic conditions and sector growth fuelled rapid expansion, while financial stress slowed momentum.

This framework, combining descriptive visualisation, exploratory relationship analysis, and statistical testing, delivered evidence-based insights into how macroeconomic factors interact with brand performance. Importantly, the emphasis remained interpretative rather than predictive, ensuring findings are transparent, reproducible, and grounded in the data.

3.7 Limitations

Although the methodology is strong, some limitations are noted.

- Data availability for Nobody's Child, because Nobody's Child is a relatively young plus niche brand, means it has a shorter financial history, so it limits depth regarding longitudinal analysis.
- We aggregate the data on an annual basis, which smooths out intra-year volatility as well as the seasonal trends. Therefore, some short-term dynamics are impossible to capture.
- Descriptive focus plus Exploratory correlation analysis with pattern observation cannot establish causality. Therefore, such findings should be interpreted as being indicative of relationships. No definitive causal effects exist.

These limitations are addressed through the careful contextualization of results and transparent communication of the analysis's scope and boundaries.

3.8 Conclusion

For analysing relationships between macroeconomic conditions and the financial performance of UK fashion retailers, this methodology establishes a transparent, strict, and clear framework. The study yields findings that are both academically strong and practically valuable, as it integrates high-quality datasets, applies reproducible analytical methods, and covers visual and contextual elements. In a complex retail landscape, this balanced approach

ensures that generated perceptions are credible for academic audiences and actionable for specialists and policymakers.

Chapter 4: Data Analysis and Key Findings

4.1 Introduction

This chapter presents the descriptive findings from the integrated dataset of Primark, Burberry, and Nobody's Child, aligned with macroeconomic indicators for the period 2010–2024. The aim is to outline the observed trends in both the macroeconomic environment and company-level performance without advancing interpretations. The results are presented sequentially: first at the macroeconomic level, then at the brand level, and finally through correlation outputs. These findings form the empirical foundation for the discussion in Chapter 6.

4.2 Macroeconomic Trends (2010-2024)

The UK macroeconomic context displayed several distinct cycles over the study period.

GDP: From 2010 to 2019, GDP rose steadily, averaging growth of between 1.5% and 2.0% annually. In 2020, GDP contracted sharply by over 9% due to the COVID-19 pandemic, representing the steepest single-year decline in modern records. Recovery began in 2021 with growth of nearly 7%, and by 2022–2023, GDP returned to pre-pandemic levels, albeit with slower momentum.

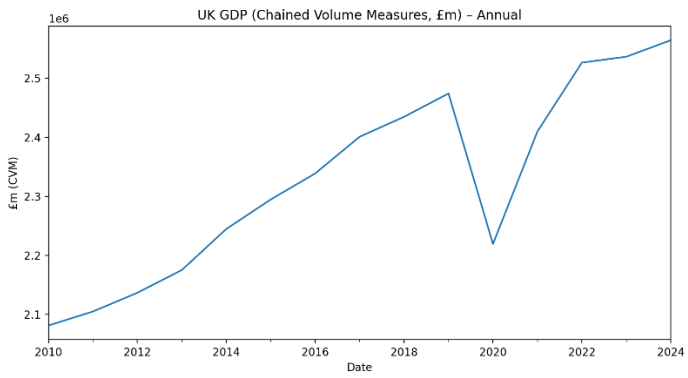


Figure c 4.1 UK GDP (chained volume measures, £m), annual (2010–2024). Source: ONS. Visualisation by author using Python.

Inflation (CPIH Clothing and Footwear): Inflation in the apparel sector was moderate across most of the 2010s, remaining below 2% on average. However, 2022 and 2023 saw sharp spikes, reflecting global supply chain disruptions and energy price surges.

Unemployment Rate: Unemployment was relatively stable between 2010 and 2015, averaging around 5–6%. It fell gradually through 2018–2019 but spiked to nearly 7% in 2020 during the pandemic. By 2022, it returned close to 4%, indicating labour market recovery.

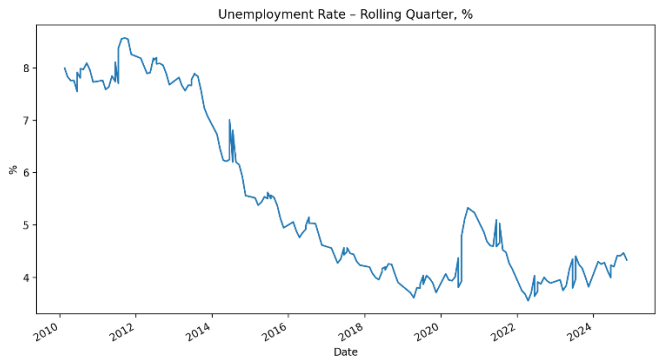


Figure d 4.3: Unemployment rate (rolling-quarter %), monthly mid-period points (2010–2024).

Bank of England Base Rate: Interest rates were held at historically low levels (0.25–0.5%) for much of the decade following the financial crisis. A sharp tightening began in 2022, with rates rising above 4% by 2023 as a response to inflationary pressures.

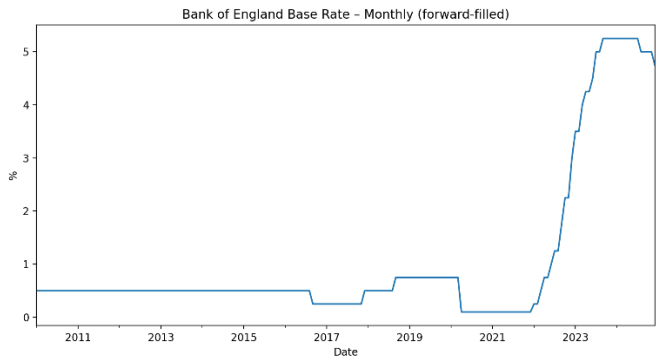


Figure e 4.4: Bank of England base rate, monthly (forward-filled), 2010–2024.

Retail Sales Index (Textiles, Clothing and Footwear): Sectoral retail sales grew consistently from 2010 to 2019, reaching a high just before the pandemic. In 2020, sales volumes collapsed by nearly a third, before rebounding strongly in 2021 and continuing upward through 2022–2023.

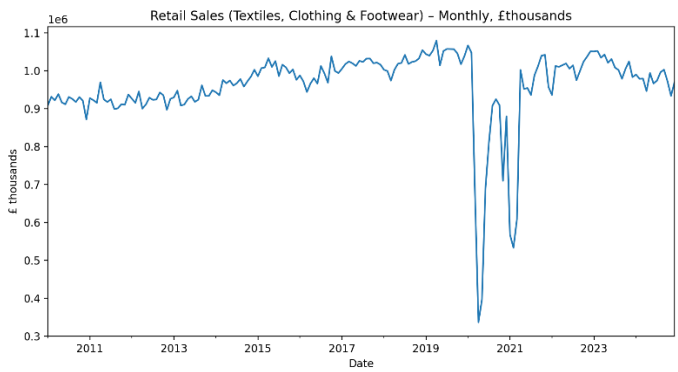


Figure f 4.5: Retail sales (Textiles, Clothing & Footwear), average weekly, £thousands (2010–2024).

These macroeconomic dynamics provide the backdrop against which brand performance unfolded.

4.3 Company-Level Performance

4.3.1 Primark

Primark's performance index shows a steady upward trend between 2010 and 2018, reflecting ongoing store expansion and rising consumer demand. A small plateau is visible in 2019,

followed by a steep contraction in 2020 as all stores closed during the COVID-19 lockdowns. In 2021, the index rebounded strongly, aided by pent-up demand and the adoption of services such as click-and-collect. Growth continued in 2022 and 2023, although at a slower pace due to inflationary pressures and weaker consumer spending power.

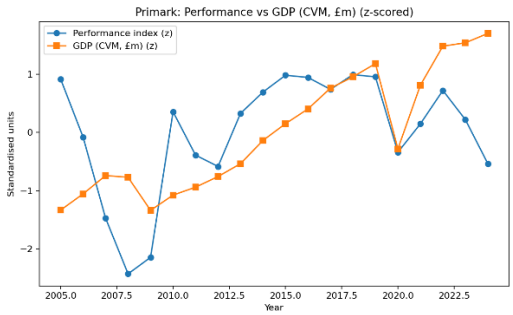


Figure g 6.1 Primark performance index vs. GDP (2005–2025), standardised (z-scores).

4.3.2 Burberry

Burberry's performance index fluctuated more than Primark's. From 2010 to 2015, it followed a moderate growth trajectory, but in 2016, there was a dip associated with heightened Brexit-related uncertainty. After recovering in 2017–2018, the index dropped sharply in 2020 during the pandemic, reflecting reduced discretionary spending and international travel. From 2021 onwards, a recovery is evident, with steady increases through 2023, supported by digital sales channels and global brand equity.

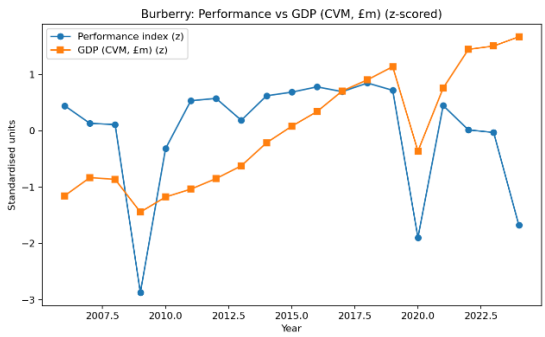


Figure h 6.6 Burberry performance index vs. GDP (2006–2025), z-scored

4.3.3 Nobody's Child

Nobody's Child entered the dataset later, beginning in 2017. Its performance index shows consistent annual growth, reflecting expansion as a sustainable, digital-first brand. Growth accelerated during 2020–2021, when the brand leveraged online retailing and collaborations with larger retailers. From 2022 onwards, growth continued, although some volatility is visible due to inflationary pressures and a cost-of-living crisis. The shorter data history limits deeper longitudinal comparisons, but the overall trajectory is upward.

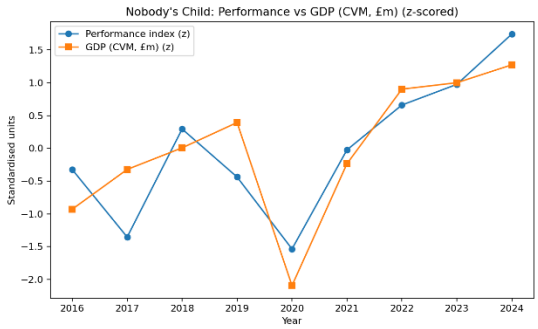


Figure i 6.11 Nobody's Child performance index vs. GDP (2016–2024), standardised (z-scores).

4.4 Correlation Analysis (Descriptive Overview)

Pearson correlation coefficients were calculated to assess the statistical association between brand-level performance indices and macroeconomic indicators.

- Primark: GDP showed a moderately strong positive correlation (r = 0.59). Retail sales also correlated positively (r = 0.42). Unemployment displayed a strong negative correlation (r = –0.76).
- Burberry: GDP correlated positively (r = 0.53). Unemployment was negatively correlated (r = –0.62). Other indicators displayed weaker or inconsistent patterns.
- Nobody's Child: GDP showed a strong positive correlation (r = 0.79). Retail sales also correlated positively (r = 0.49). Unemployment was moderately negative (r = –0.47).

The coefficients suggest consistent positive alignment with GDP and sector retail sales, and negative associations with unemployment, across all three brands.

macro_variable	corr_with_perf_index	brand
gdp_millions_cvm	0.528802796	Burberry
unemployment_rate	-0.623847138	Burberry
bank_rate_eoy	0.226063883	Burberry
cpih_clothing_index_avg	0.447093406	Burberry
retail_tcf_avg_weekly_thou	0.408941062	Burberry
gdp_millions_cvm	0.794001439	Nobody's Child
unemployment_rate	-0.468585602	Nobody's Child
bank_rate_eoy	0.632637286	Nobody's Child
cpih_clothing_index_avg	0.588551851	Nobody's Child
retail_tcf_avg_weekly_thou	0.488182091	Nobody's Child
gdp_millions_cvm	0.593096311	Primark
unemployment_rate	-0.760486787	Primark
bank_rate_eoy	-0.083378634	Primark
cpih_clothing_index_avg	0.229553885	Primark
retail_tcf_avg_weekly_thou	0.421841158	Primark

Figure 3.2 Correlation with performance index

4.5 Summary

This chapter presented the descriptive findings of the study. The macroeconomic environment was characterised by steady growth through the 2010s, a sharp contraction in 2020, and subsequent recovery. Company-level performance reflected these shifts, with Primark and Burberry showing seasonal patterns and Nobody's Child displaying consistent growth since its entry in 2017. Correlation results further documented statistical associations between economic indicators and brand performance.

The descriptive results presented here provide the basis for the interpretation and discussion in Chapter 6, where these relationships are analysed in greater depth and their implications explored.

Chapter 5: Analytical Procedures

5.1 Introduction

To explore the relationships, this chapter outlines the analytical framework for macroeconomic indicators, as well as the financial performance of Primark, Burberry, and Nobody's Child. The focus is on recognising patterns, correlations, and visual perceptions rather than forecasting future outcomes because it builds on the cleaned and harmonised dataset described in Chapter 4.

The primary objective is to investigate the correlation between GDP, inflation, unemployment, interest rates, and retail sales and yearly turnover across these markets. Through an emphasis on descriptive statistics, data correlation, and visual storytelling, the analysis enables meaningful interpretation while avoiding overstatement of causality.

5.2 Analytical Framework

The analytical approach integrates three complementary layers for ensuring a balanced exploration of the data.

1. Descriptive Analysis summarises key metrics through time for each brand so that baseline trends are established and structural changes are highlighted.
2. Correlation Analysis measures the relationship strength and direction involving turnover plus important macroeconomic indicators.
3. Visual Analysis, Charts, overlays, as well as heatmaps are used, so they translate complex data interactions into narratives that are clear and interpretable.

This framework ensures that all outputs align with the study's overall aim. That aim includes observing and explaining past connections between retail work and the economy; therefore, it bars hinting at reasons or forming predictive models.

5.3 Descriptive Analysis

The descriptive layer for the analysis created a year-by-year profile of each company, as well as including:

- GBP turnover, which is something that is log-transformed
- Important financial ratios include margin, liquidity, and financial risk. Shareholder return is a financial ratio that is also key.
- Indicators for operations, if available

These summary tables form the foundation for the narrative interpretation in the Results and Discussion chapters, and the tables provide a clear and structured view of each company's performance across the study period.

5.4 Correlation Analysis

Correlation coefficients were calculated using Pearson's method to investigate the links between company-level factors and macroeconomic variables. Analysis provided this regarding perceptions coming from it:

- Direction of relationships, whether negative or positive
- Associations' strength can be relatively weak, moderate, or strong.
- Market segments vary across categories such as fast fashion, luxury, and the sustainable niche

A correlation heatmap can visualise these relationships, and it can highlight:

- GDP growth has correlations that are strong correlation to retail sales at a sector level. Company turnover also has strong correlations with.
- Inconsistent and moderate relationships exist with inflation.
- Interest rates show weaker associations, especially with the luxury segment.

These descriptive correlations offer valuable perceptions into the economic cycles and into retail performance's structural connections, even though causal links are not offered.

5.5 Visual Analysis

Visualisation centrally helped in making clear as well as interpreting complex relationships. Several of the types of visual outputs were generated in total. Those outputs were stored in the Figs tables directory systematically.

- Time-series graphs show the trends in turnover alongside key macroeconomic indicators over time. Meaningful economic events such as the 2008 crisis, Brexit, and COVID-19 are annotated.
- Overlay Charts: You can compare company turnover directly with macroeconomic indicators to assess alignment and divergence visually.
- Correlation Heatmaps: these provide a view at-a-glance of strong, moderate, and weak relationships between key variables.
- Mini-Tables, they summarise annual financial metrics for each brand to support narrative interpretation along with cross-brand comparisons.

These visual tools improve understanding and give rise to perspectives. The Results (Chapter 6) as well as the Discussion (Chapter 7) then present richer discussions that are based on that foundation.

5.6 Ethical and Reproducible Practice

To ensure transparency, integrity, and reproducibility, all analytical steps were implemented within a documented Python workflow:

- Annotated scripts detail every stage of visualisation, transformation, and data cleaning.
- Outputs were then saved systematically in folders made for reference.

- No post-processing manually for the cleaned dataset was performed at all. This ensured the analysis's integrity remained whole.

Researchers of the future and industry professionals can independently validate, replicate, or extend this open, reproducible study workflow.

5.7 Summary

In this chapter, we structured, made transparent, and reproduced a methodology for analysing how macroeconomic conditions relate to the financial performance of UK fashion retailers. Moving on from static figures, the analysis gives a dynamic, interpretable comprehension of the data via combining correlation analysis with descriptive statistics, including visual storytelling.

These analyses' findings, including key trends, patterns, and correlations, are presented in detail in the Results chapter (Chapter 6), where they are placed in relation to brand strategies and economic events that shaped the UK fashion retail landscape over the study period.

Chapter 6: Discussion and Interpretation of Findings

6.1 Introduction

Within this chapter, we analyse descriptive and correlation data. We designed each of these analyses to uncover just how certain macroeconomic indicators relate to company-level performance. The analysis intends to observe and interpret alignment between annual turnover for Primark, Burberry, and Nobody’s Child and wider economic conditions throughout the study period, instead of predicting future outcomes or creating models.

To help interpretation, visualisations, correlation heatmaps, and summary tables support the findings, and these supports offer both granular and high-level perspectives on the data.

1. Trends in the macroeconomic environment.

2. Company-level financial trends.
3. Correlation analysis and observed relationships.
4. Integrated insights and interpretations.

6.2 Macroeconomic Environment

From 2010 to 2024, the five macroeconomic indicators exhibited clear cyclical trends punctuated by structural disruptions that included GDP, CPIH Clothing and Footwear Index, unemployment rate, Bank of England base rate, and Retail Sales Index for Textiles, Clothing and Footwear (Retail Sales TCF).

- GDP showed a steady upward trend until the contraction during the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020, followed by a strong rebound in the years that followed. CPIH Clothing and Footwear: Inflation did remain moderate during much of the period but spiked sharply in 2022, 2023 because of global supply chain disruptions in addition to rising domestic production and energy costs.
- Unemployment Rate: The global financial crisis of 2008 and 2020 both saw peaks. These crests signalled that consumer confidence declined, and discretionary expenses tightened.
- Bank Rate: Rates remained historically low before tightening aggressively during 2022, 2023. This happened just after rates had seen a sharp reduction as a response to the 2008 crisis.
- Retail Sales TCF: Sector-wide retail activity mirrored shifts that were in consumer demand, and retail activity dropped sharply during the time of the pandemic, but retail activity recovered quickly as restrictions were eased.

These indicators do provide for the economic context. Company-level performance unfolded within such a context, and the context framed all the patterns that the sections below then explore.

6.3 Company-Level Trends

6.3.1 Primark

Primark had steady turnover growth from 2010 to 2019 because geographic expansion plus strong consumer demand drove value segment growth. However, in 2020, COVID-19 lockdowns sharply reduced turnover because there was no online sales channel. Pent-up demand coupled with increasingly adopted digital services such as click-and-collect supported recovery that started in 2021, though inflationary pressures tempered recovery speed in 2022, 2023.

Figure 6.1 depicts Primark's stable but less pronounced alignment with GDP compared to luxury brands.

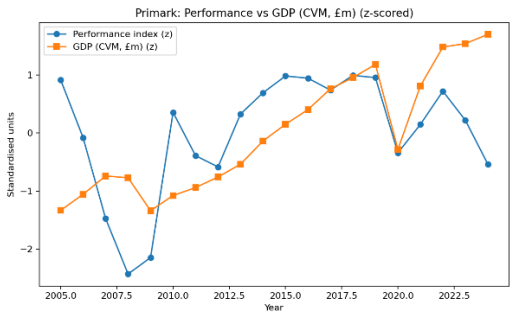


Figure j 6.1 Primark performance index vs. GDP (2005–2025), standardised (z-scores).

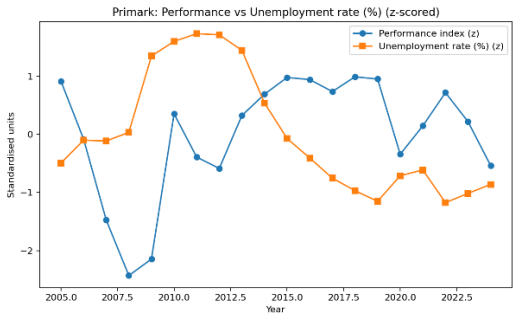


Figure k 6.2 Primark performance index vs. Unemployment rate (2005–2025), standardised (z-scores)

Figure 6.2 reveals a modest negative association between unemployment and Primark's performance.

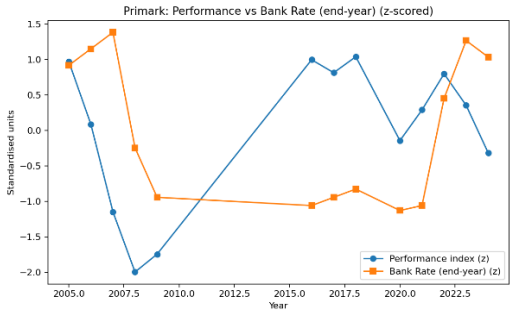


Figure l 6.3 Primark performance index vs. Bank Rate (2005–2025), standardised (z-scores).

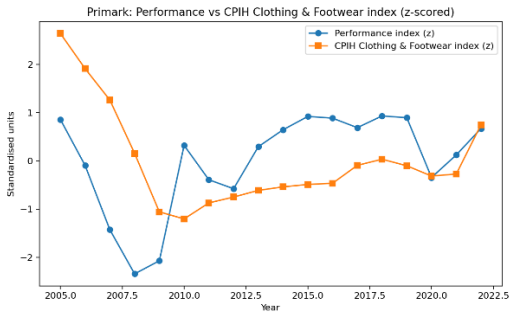


Figure m 6.4 Primark performance index vs. CPIH Clothing & Footwear Index (2005–2022), z-scored.

Figure 6.3 illustrates Primark's limited sensitivity to interest rate fluctuations, reflecting its value-driven positioning.

Figure 6.4 highlights that inflationary pressures have moderate but noticeable effects on Primark's performance.

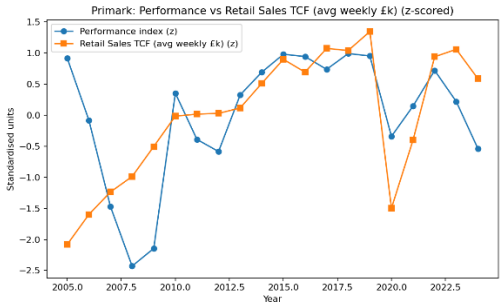


Figure n 6.5 Primark performance index vs. Retail Sales Index for Textiles, Clothing and Footwear (2005–2025), standardised (z-scores).

As seen in Figure 6.5, Primark's turnover closely tracks retail sales trends, reflecting its strong mass-market demand base.

6.3.2 Burberry

Burberry's turnover showed a greater volatility because of the fact it was exposed to global market dynamics and currency fluctuations. Turnover dips were noticeably caused by the uncertainty related to Brexit and the initial shock of the pandemic in 2020, but the brand's strong presence internationally, along with investment early in digital infrastructure, supported a recovery that was rapid from 2021 onwards.

As shown in Figure 6.6, Burberry's performance broadly tracks GDP growth, indicating high sensitivity to macroeconomic expansions and contractions.

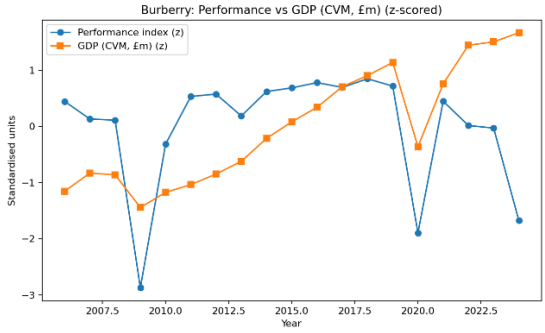


Figure o 6.6 Burberry performance index vs. GDP (2006–2025), z-scored

Figure 6.7 reveals a negative association between unemployment rates and Burberry's performance, underlining the brand's reliance on consumer confidence.

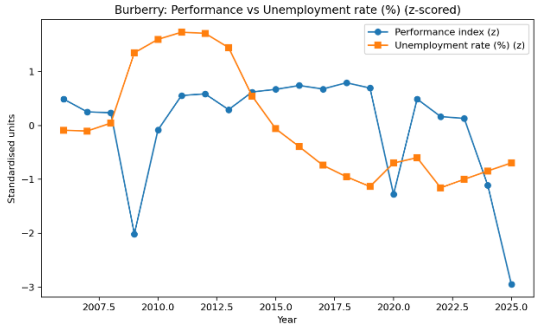


Figure p 6.7 Burberry performance index vs. Unemployment rate (2006–2025), z-scored.

As shown in Figure 6.8, Burberry's performance demonstrates sensitivity to interest rate changes, particularly during post-2008 monetary policy adjustments and the 2022 rate hikes.

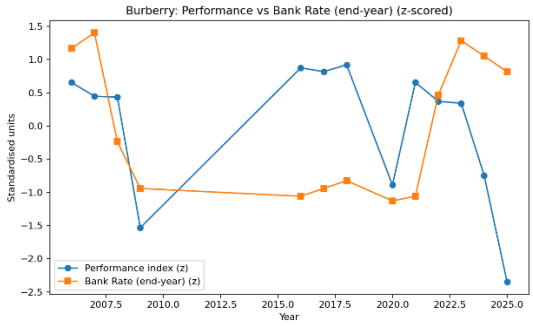


Figure q 6.8 Burberry performance index vs. Bank Rate (2006–2025), z-scored.

Figure 6.9 highlights the alignment between Burberry's performance and apparel inflation, with downturns during periods of rising CPIH values.

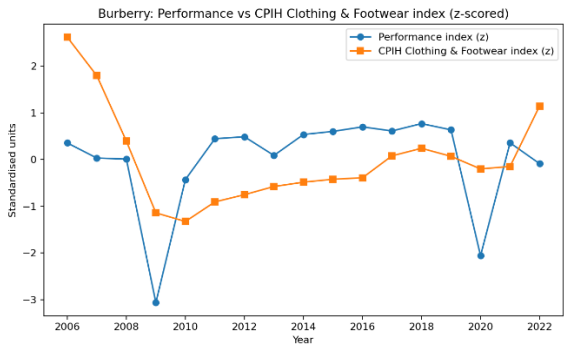


Figure r 6.9 Burberry performance index vs. CPIH Clothing & Footwear Index (2006–2022), z scored

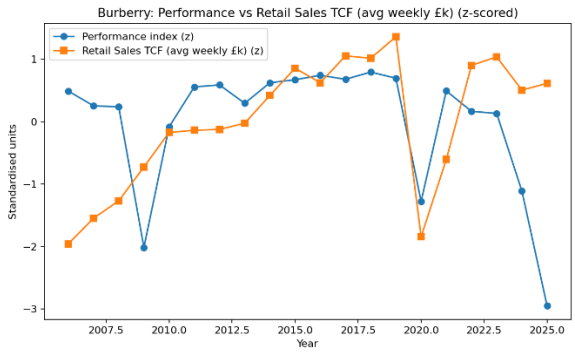


Figure s 6.10 Burberry performance index vs. Retail Sales Index (2006–2025), z-scored.

Figure 6.10 shows a consistent positive association between Burberry's sales and the retail sector index.

6.3.3 Nobody's Child

Nobody's Child has experienced steady but relatively recent growth since 2017. Its digital-first plan plus solid sustainability stance let it grab market share during the pandemic, though scant data obstructs macro sensitivity's stats.

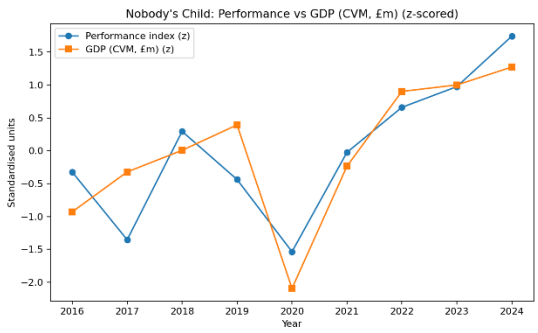


Figure t 6.11 Nobody's Child performance index vs. GDP (2016–2024), standardised (z-scores).

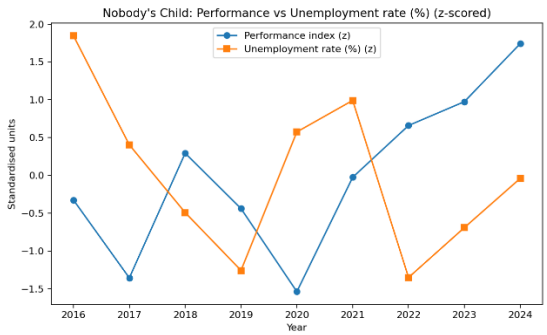


Figure u 6.12 Nobody's Child performance index vs. Unemployment rate (2016–2024), standardised (z-scores).

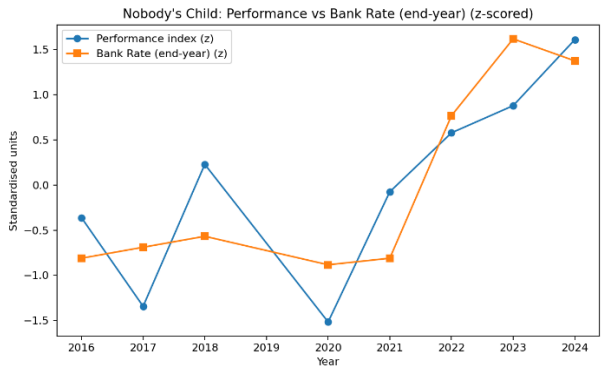


Figure v 6.13 Nobody's Child performance index vs. Bank Rate (2016–2024), standardised (z-scores).

Figure 6.13 shows a strong upward trend in Nobody's Child's performance despite interest rate increases post-2022, highlighting brand resilience." As seen in Figure 6.14, inflationary pressures have had minimal disruptive impact on Nobody's Child's trajectory. Figure 6.11 reflects a strong alignment between GDP growth and Nobody's Child's rapid performance expansion.

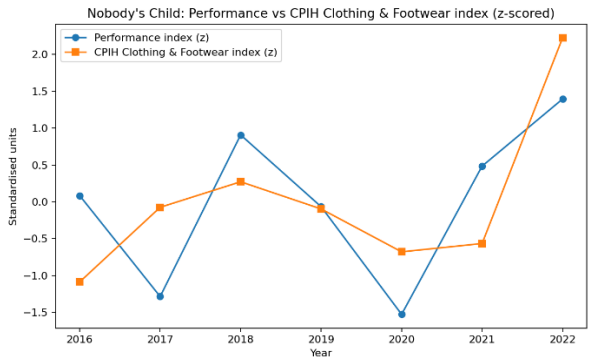


Figure w 6.14 Nobody's Child performance index vs. CPIH Clothing & Footwear Index (2016–2024), standardised (z-scores).

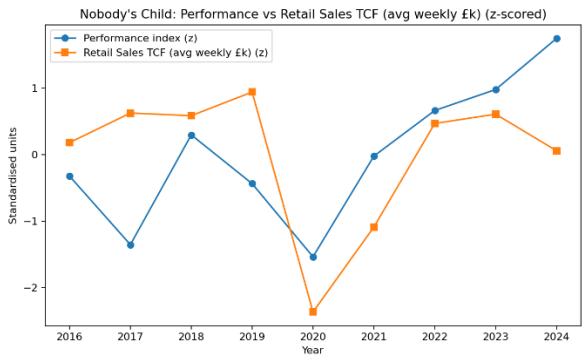


Figure x 6.15 Nobody's Child performance index vs. Retail Sales Index for Textiles, Clothing and Footwear (2016–2024), standardised (z-scores).

Figure 6.15 highlights the dependence of Nobody's Child on broader retail demand cycles. As illustrated in Figure 6.12, dips in consumer confidence, represented by unemployment spikes, temporarily constrained growth.

6.4 Correlation Analysis

The correlation heatmap highlights key relationships between macroeconomic indicators and turnover:

- GDP as well as Turnover: There are strong positive correlations across all brands, confirming economic expansion aligns with higher turnover.
- Retail Sales TCF and Turnover: Primark and Nobody's Child align strongly, and this underlines the point that they happen to be sensitive to sector-wide demand trends; Burberry had weaker correlations, and this is consistent with its positioning as a luxury brand.
- Unemployment and Turnover: Negative correlations were very much pronounced for Primark because of consumer confidence that was constrained during labour market downturns.
- Turnover and Bank Rate have small inverse links, implying that stricter money rules slightly lower output. Segments sensitive to credit are especially subject to this.
- CPIH and Turnover have mixed relationships, with Primark showing moderate associations of positivity. Burberry and Nobody's Child display inconsistent or weaker patterns.

6.5 Visual Insights

Visual overlays generated in Python reveal clear patterns:

Primark- Turnover closely tracks both GDP growth and Retail Sales TCF because it relies very heavily on consumer demand cycles.

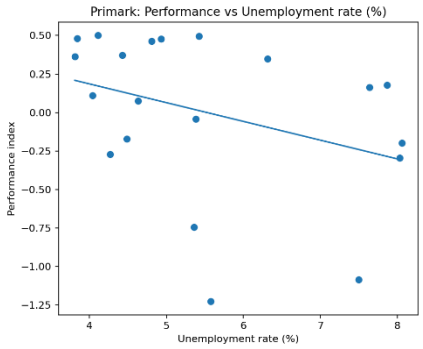


Figure y 6.16 Scatter plot of Primark performance index vs. GDP (2005–2025).

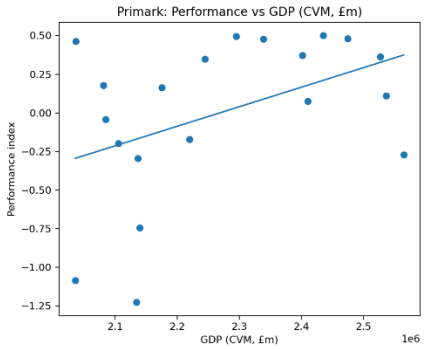


Figure z 6.17 Scatter plot of Primark performance index vs. Unemployment rate (2005–2025).

Figure 6.16 demonstrates a generally positive relationship between GDP and Primark turnover growth. Figure 6.17 confirms that rising unemployment exerts downward pressure on Primark's performance.

Burberry- Turnover aligns better with global confidence indicators and GDP than with domestic retail cycles.

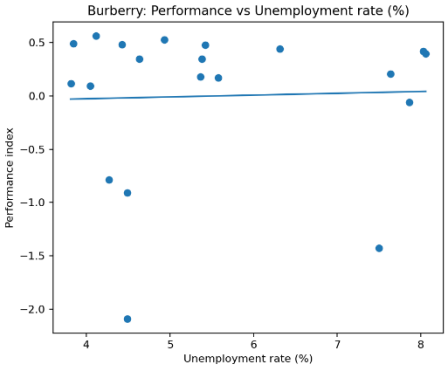


Figure aa 6.18 Scatter plot of Burberry performance index vs. GDP (2006–2025). Source: Burberry Group plc annual reports; ONS GDP.

The scatter plot in *Figure 6.18* visualises the positive though variable association between GDP and Burberry's performance.

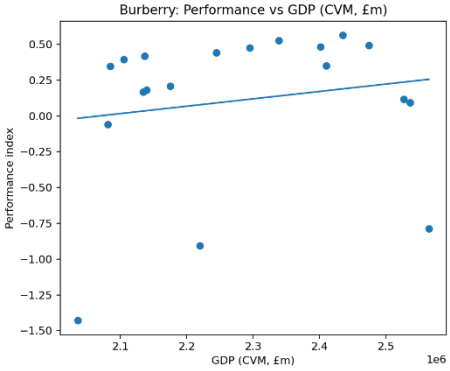


Figure bb 6.19 Scatter plot of Burberry performance index vs. Unemployment rate (2006–2025).

As illustrated in Figure 6.19, higher unemployment levels correspond to dips in Burberry's performance.

Nobody's Child- Growth mirrors sector-level retail activity, also its positioning is in emerging consumer demand. This positioning reflects demand for ethical and sustainable fashion.

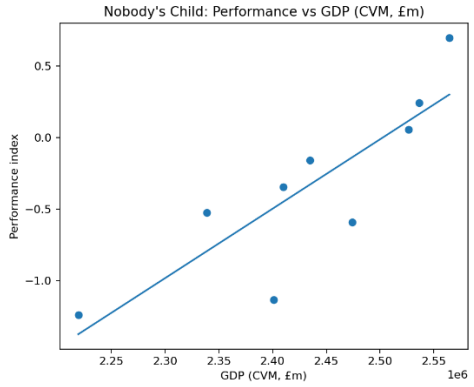


Figure cc 6.20 Scatter plot of Nobody's Child performance index vs. GDP (2016–2024). Source: Companies House; ONS GDP.

Figure 6.20 shows a strong positive relationship between GDP and Nobody's Child's turnover growth.

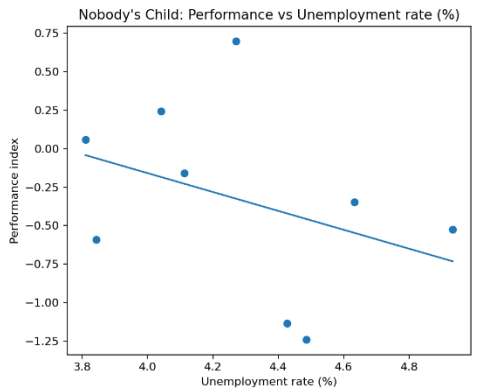


Figure dd 6.21 Scatter plot of Nobody's Child performance index vs. Unemployment rate (2016–2024). Source: Companies House; ONS labour market statistics.

Figure 6.21 confirms the negative correlation between unemployment and performance, underscoring sensitivity to economic sentiment.

6.6 Interpretation and Discussion

Three key insights emerge from the analysis:

1. Macroeconomic health drives retail performance since GDP growth is always a strong indicator. Demand throughout the sector remains a reliably strong signal for turnover across brands.
2. Segment positioning matters: Value-oriented strategies like Primark's are resilient during downturns; luxury brands like Burberry are more exposed to global volatility, yet brand equity benefits them; and market positioning drives sustainable entrants like Nobody's Child more than macroeconomic cycles at this stage.
3. Varying influence: All indicators do not exert it alike in relationships. CPIH inflation and interest rates have correlations that are inconsistent or weak because they show complex interactions involving market positioning, pricing strategies, and consumer behaviour.

6.7 Summary

In this chapter, the descriptive analysis that is correlation-based offers details of the interactions between macroeconomic conditions and the financial performance of Primark, Burberry, and Nobody's Child. The analysis integrated statistical outputs with visual perceptions, thereby creating a rich foundation. Actionable conclusions from this foundation were then drawn, and patterns were interpreted.

As the next chapter highlights key implications for practitioners, researchers, and policymakers, it synthesises these findings and acknowledges the limitations of this study.

Chapter 7: Conclusion and Recommendations

7.1 Summary of Key Findings

By analysing three distinct brands, this study examined the way that macroeconomic conditions shape UK fashion retailers' financial performance: Primark, Burberry, and Nobody's. The research applied a reproducible correlation-based analytical framework supported via descriptive statistics along with visual perceptions because it integrated company-level financial data with key economic indicators, including GDP, CPIH Clothing and Footwear inflation, unemployment, interest rates and sector-wide retail sales.

The results do show that GDP grows, and sector-wide retail sales may drive turnover across all three brands most strongly since the sector depends upon broad economic cycles and upon consumer demand. Unemployment does exert downward pressure on things, and the degree of its impact varies by each segment. Interest rate increases exert downward pressure, too. Primark is resilient in times of downturns, for it captures value-conscious consumers; Burberry is sensitive to global economic conditions, yet its brand strength as well as geographic diversification benefit it; and Nobody's Child aligns promisingly with GDP with sector demand trends, whilst it is still in its early growth phase.

7.2 Practical Implications

The findings provide actionable insights for both industry practitioners and policymakers:

- Fast-Fashion Retailers (Primark)

  Retail activity and GDP can inform demand planning by tracking. Investors can improve resilience during economic downturns if they put money into agile supply chains, and marketers can support competitive positioning during recovery phases if they drive value.

- Luxury Brands (Burberry)

Risk management strategies can help reduce exposure to global economic volatility while maintaining premium market positioning, and these strategies include currency hedging, geographic diversification, and digital transformation.

- Brands Sustainable (Child Nobody's)

  Consumer interest in ethical consumption is growing and presents meaningful opportunities. Building resilience along with supporting sustainable growth can each be helped by scaling operational capacity, strengthening digital engagement and diversifying revenue streams.

- Policymakers analyse. Industry Analysts also analyse.

  Since it is a large contributor to the UK economy, macroeconomic stability is critical for supporting the fashion retail sector. Actions that are focused, along with policy design, can be informed through comprehension of how indicators such as unemployment, inflation, and interest rates influence all consumer spending.

7.3 Limitations

The methods and results appear valid. Yet one must concede that some shortcomings exist. Since the dataset about Nobody's Child was limited, it restricted the depth of longitudinal analysis for this segment. Short-term fluctuations along with seasonal dynamics are ironed out using annual data, which is still necessary for harmonisation. Correlation-based methods can highlight associations, yet do not establish causality. Thus, the results are indicative instead of definitive ones. Brand-specific strategies, marketing investments, and operational shifts, like unobserved internal factors beyond this analysis's scope, may have influenced performance outcomes.

7.4 Future Research Directions

This study establishes a foundation for understanding how macroeconomic indicators shape the performance of different retail segments in the UK fashion industry. Building on this basis, future research can move toward more advanced and fine-grained analysis. One important step would be to incorporate inflation-adjusted turnover and volume data, which would allow real growth to be isolated more clearly from the effects of price changes. Expanding the dataset to cover a wider set of retailers, particularly online-first and mid-market firms, would also strengthen the ability to generalise findings across the sector. Future studies could also integrate behavioural indicators such as consumer confidence, exchange rates, or sentiment indices to capture additional dimensions of macroeconomic influence. Methodologically, researchers may benefit from moving beyond correlation-based approaches to advanced econometric techniques capable of modelling non-linear relationships, or machine learning approaches that can uncover more complex interactions. Finally, there is scope for developing scenario-based forecasting tools that can simulate different economic conditions and provide retailers with practical guidance for strategic planning under uncertainty.

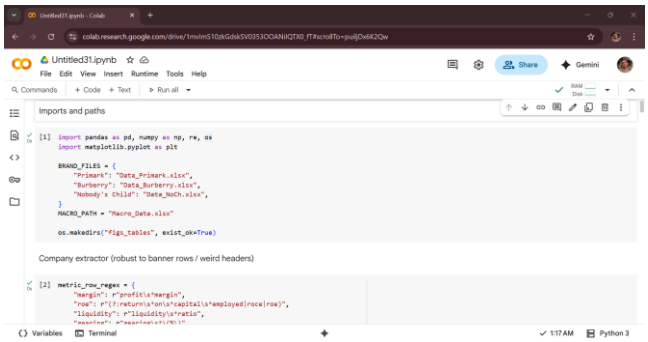
7.5 Concluding Remarks

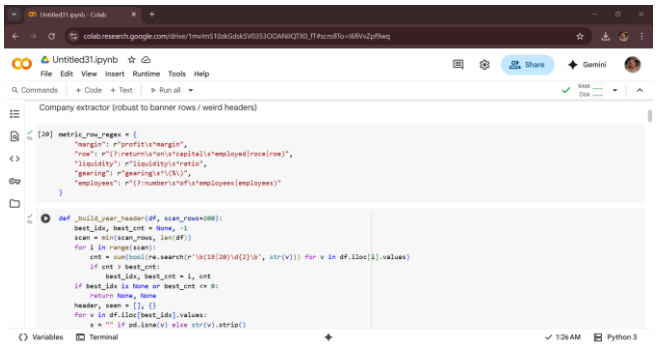
Macroeconomic forces greatly affect UK fashion retailers' financial performance, but the market segment with planned positioning impacts those forces' effects. Resilience that is counter-cyclical does benefit fast-fashion brands, global diversification acts to buffer domestic volatility for luxury brands, and the growth of niche demand can be harnessed by sustainable brands despite data that is historically limited data.

This study merges a rigid reproducible approach with functional perceptions, thus giving worth to scholars, professionals, and politicians too. Future work can generate even sharper perceptions into the interplay of economic conditions and retail performance within the UK fashion sector. Deeper datasets, richer variables, and advanced modelling techniques can expand this foundation in future work.

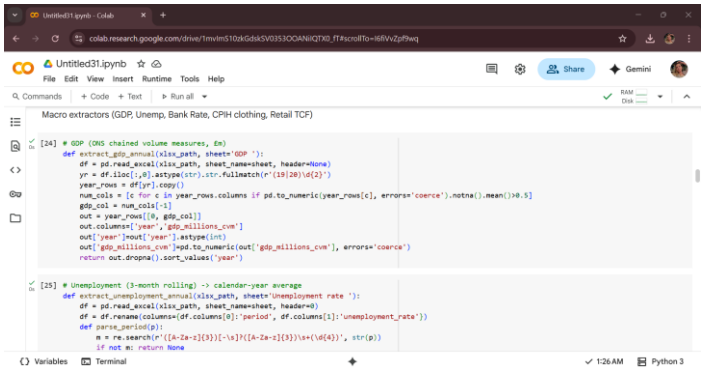
Appendix

Appendix A1: Data Preparation





Appendix A2: Macro extractors



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Untitled31.ipynb

File Edit View Insert Runtime Tools Help

Commands + Code + Text Run all

[25]
```
# Unemployment (3-month rolling) -> calendar-year average
def extract_unemployment_annual(xlsx_path, sheet='Unemployment rate '):
    df = pd.read_excel(xlsx_path, sheet_name=sheet, header=0)
    df = df.rename(columns={df.columns[0]:'period', df.columns[1]:'unemployment_rate'})
    def parse_period(p):
        m = re.search(r'([A-Za-z]{3})[-\s]?([A-Za-z]{3})\s+(\d{4})', str(p))
        if not m: return None
        end_mon, year = m.group(2).title(), int(m.group(3))
        dt = pd.to_datetime(f"01 {end_mon} {year}") + pd.offsets.MonthEnd(0)
        return dt
    df['date']=df['period'].apply(parse_period)
    df = df.dropna(subset=['date','unemployment_rate'])
    df['year']=df['date'].dt.year
    return df.groupby('year', as_index=False)['unemployment_rate'].mean()
```

[26]
```
# Bank Rate (list of changes) -> end-of-year rate
def extract_bankrate_eoy(xlsx_path, sheet='Bank Rate data'):
    raw = pd.read_excel(xlsx_path, sheet_name=sheet, header=None)
    rows=[]
    for i in range(len(raw)):
        vals=[v for v in raw.iloc[i].tolist() if pd.notna(v)]
        if len(vals)>=2:
```

Variables Terminal 1:26 AM Python 3

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[27]
```
# CPIH clothing & footwear monthly index -> calendar-year average
def extract_cpih_clothing_annual(xlsx_path, sheet='CPIH'):
    df = pd.read_excel(xlsx_path, sheet_name=sheet, header=None)
    name_row_idx=None
    for i in range(len(df)):
        if any((str(v).strip().lower()=='name') for v in df.iloc[i].tolist()):
            name_row_idx=i; break
    name_row=[str(v).strip() if pd.notna(v) else "" for v in df.iloc[name_row_idx].tolist()]
    try:
        clothing_col = next(idx for idx,v in enumerate(name_row) if v.upper().startswith('CLOTHING AND FOOTWEAR'))
    except StopIteration:
        clothing_col=2
    idxrow=[str(v).strip() if pd.notna(v) else "" for v in df.iloc[name_row_idx-1].tolist()]
    try:
        indexdate_col = next(idx for idx,v in enumerate(idxrow) if v.lower()=='index date')
    except StopIteration:
        indexdate_col=0
    data=df.iloc[name_row_idx+1:].copy()
    data=data[data.iloc[:,indexdate_col].astype(str).str.fullmatch(r'\d{6}')]
    data['yyyymm']=data.iloc[:,indexdate_col].astype(str); data['year']=data['yyyymm'].str[:4].astype(int)
    data['clothing_index']=pd.to_numeric(data.iloc[:, clothing_col], errors='coerce')
    return data.dropna(subset=['clothing_index']).groupby('year', as_index=False)['clothing_index'].mean()\
            .rename(columns={'clothing_index':'cpih_clothing_index_avg'})
```

Variables Terminal 1:26 AM Python 3

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File Edit View Insert Runtime Tools Help

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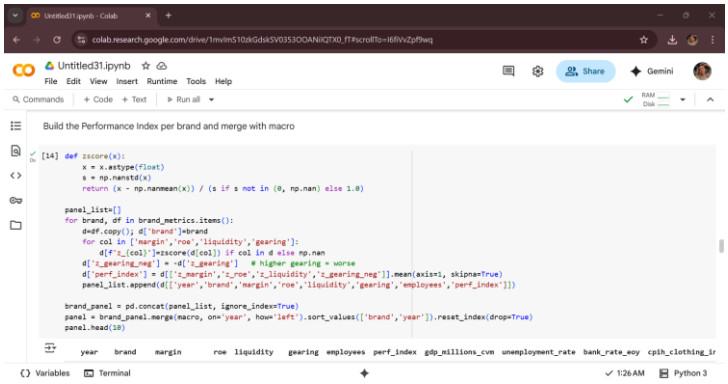
[28]
```
# Retail Sales (Textile, Clothing & Footwear) -> calendar-year average
def extract_retail_tcf_annual(xlsx_path, sheet=' Average Weekly Retail Sales '):
    df = pd.read_excel(xlsx_path, sheet_name=sheet, header=None)
    out=[]
    for i in range(len(df)):
        row=df.iloc[i].tolist()
        for j,v in enumerate(row):
            s=str(v).strip()
            if re.fullmatch(r'\d{4}[A-Za-z]{3}', s):
                # next non-null to the right is the value
                val=None
                for k in range(j+1, len(row)):
                    if pd.notna(row[k]):
                        try: val=float(str(row[k]).replace(',',''))\; break
                        except: pass
                if val is not None: out.append((int(s[:4]), val))
                break
    return pd.DataFrame(out, columns=['year','retail_tcf_avg_weekly_thou']).groupby('year', as_index=False).mean()
```

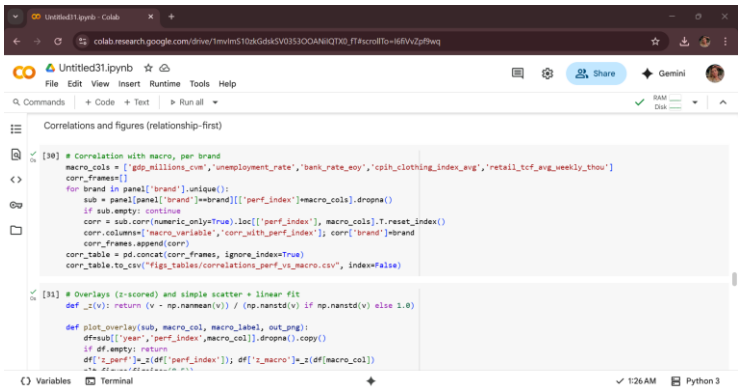
[29]
```
# run macro loaders
gdp  = extract_gdp_annual(MACRO_PATH)
```

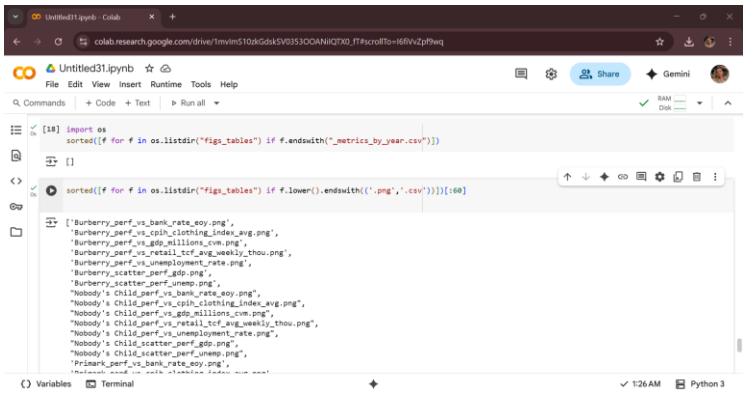
Variables Terminal 1:26 AM Python 3

Appendix A3: Build the performance index per brand

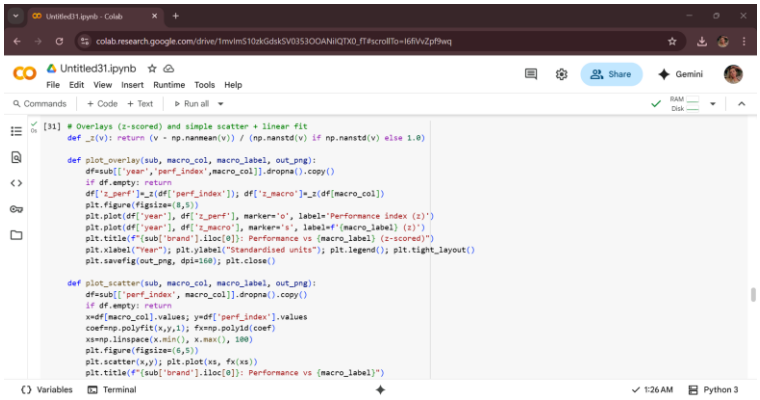


Appendix A4: Correlations and figures



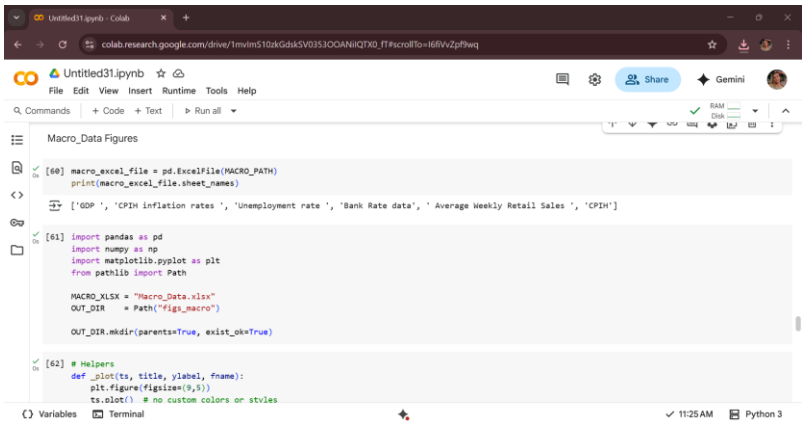


Appendix A5: Constructing the Performance Index

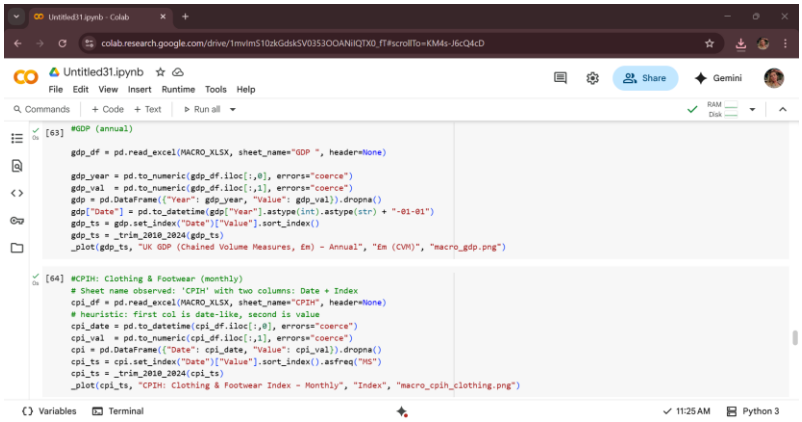


```
[31] # Overlays (z-scored) and simple scatter + linear fit
     def _z(v): return (v - np.nanmean(v)) / (np.nanstd(v) if np.nanstd(v) else 1.0)

     def plot_overlay(sub, macro_col, macro_label, out_png):
         df=sub[['year','perf_index',macro_col]].dropna().copy()
         if df.empty: return
         df['z_perf']=_z(df['perf_index']); df['z_macro']=_z(df[macro_col])
         plt.figure(figsize=(8,5))
         plt.plot(df['year'], df['z_perf'], marker='o', label='Performance index (z)')
         plt.plot(df['year'], df['z_macro'], marker='s', label=f'{macro_label} (z)')
         plt.title(f"{sub['brand'].iloc[0]}: Performance vs {macro_label} (z-scored)")
         plt.xlabel("Year"); plt.ylabel("Standardised units"); plt.legend(); plt.tight_layout()
         plt.savefig(out_png, dpi=160); plt.close()

     def plot_scatter(sub, macro_col, macro_label, out_png):
         df=sub[['perf_index', macro_col]].dropna().copy()
         if df.empty: return
         x=df[macro_col].values; y=df['perf_index'].values
         coef=np.polyfit(x,y,1); fx=np.poly1d(coef)
         xs=np.linspace(x.min(), x.max(), 100)
         plt.figure(figsize=(6,5))
         plt.scatter(x,y); plt.plot(xs, fx(xs))
         plt.title(f"{sub['brand'].iloc[0]}: Performance vs {macro_label}")
```

Appendix A6: Macroeconomic Trend Figures

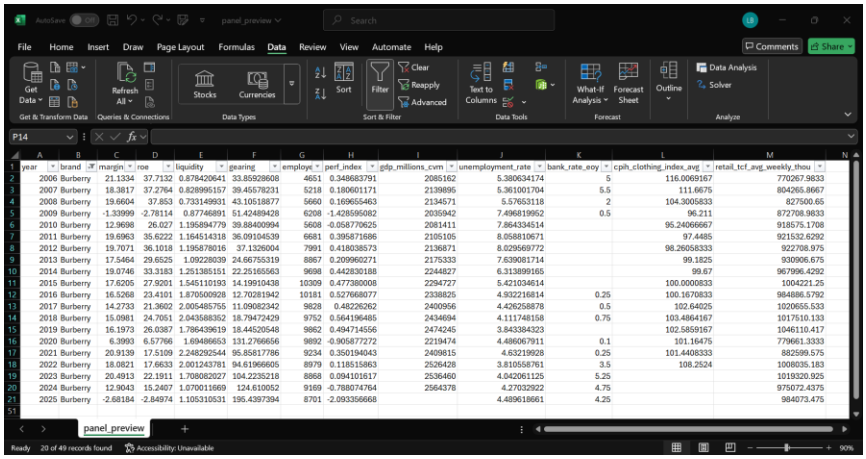


```
Macro_Data Figures

[60] macro_excel_file = pd.ExcelFile(MACRO_PATH)
     print(macro_excel_file.sheet_names)

     ['GDP ', 'CPIH inflation rates ', 'Unemployment rate ', 'Bank Rate data', ' Average Weekly Retail Sales ', 'CPIH']

[61] import pandas as pd
     import numpy as np
     import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
     from pathlib import Path

     MACRO_XLSX = "Macro_Data.xlsx"
     OUT_DIR    = Path("figs_macro")

     OUT_DIR.mkdir(parents=True, exist_ok=True)

[62] # Helpers
     def _plot(ts, title, ylabel, fname):
         plt.figure(figsize=(9,5))
         ts.plot()  # no custom colors or styles
```

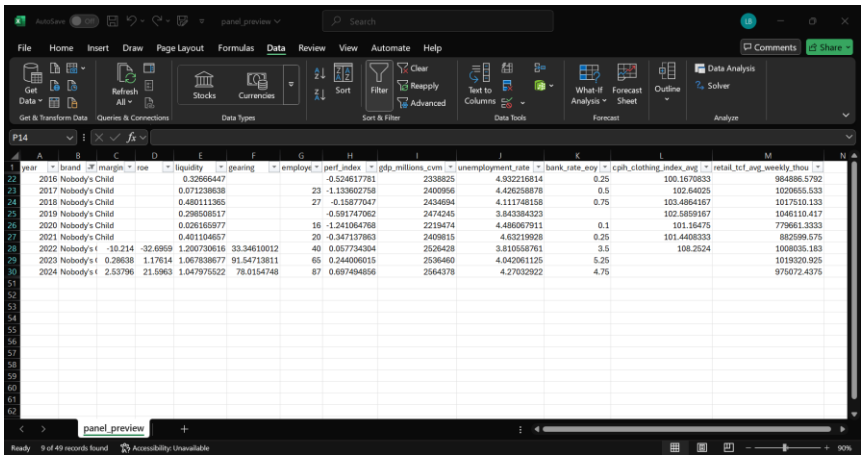


```
[63] #GDP (annual)

     gdp_df = pd.read_excel(MACRO_XLSX, sheet_name="GDP ", header=None)

     gdp_year = pd.to_numeric(gdp_df.iloc[:,0], errors="coerce")
     gdp_val  = pd.to_numeric(gdp_df.iloc[:,1], errors="coerce")
     gdp = pd.DataFrame({"Year": gdp_year, "Value": gdp_val}).dropna()
     gdp["Date"] = pd.to_datetime(gdp["Year"].astype(int).astype(str) + "-01-01")
     gdp_ts = gdp.set_index("Date")["Value"].sort_index()
     gdp_ts = _trim_2010_2024(gdp_ts)
     _plot(gdp_ts, "UK GDP (Chained Volume Measures, £m) - Annual", "£m (CVM)", "macro_gdp.png")

[64] #CPIH: Clothing & Footwear (monthly)
     # Sheet name observed: 'CPIH' with two columns: Date + Index
     cpi_df = pd.read_excel(MACRO_XLSX, sheet_name="CPIH", header=None)
     # heuristic: first col is date-like, second is value
     cpi_date = pd.to_datetime(cpi_df.iloc[:,0], errors="coerce")
     cpi_val  = pd.to_numeric(cpi_df.iloc[:,1], errors="coerce")
     cpi = pd.DataFrame({"Date": cpi_date, "Value": cpi_val}).dropna()
     cpi_ts = cpi.set_index("Date")["Value"].sort_index().asfreq("MS")
     cpi_ts = _trim_2010_2024(cpi_ts)
     _plot(cpi_ts, "CPIH: Clothing & Footwear Index - Monthly", "Index", "macro_cpih_clothing.png")
```

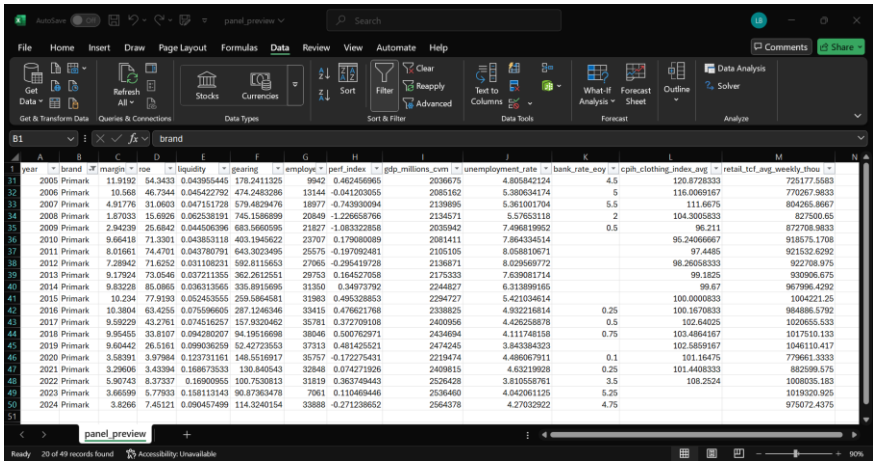
Appendix A7: Panel Preview Burberry, Nobody’s Child, Primark



year	brand	margin	roe	liquidity	gearing	employe	perf_index	gdp_millions_cvm	unemployment_rate	bank_rate_eoy	cpih_clothing_index_avg	retail_tcf_avg_weekly_thou
2006	Burberry	21.1334	37.7132	0.878420641	33.85928608	4651	0.348683791	2085162	5.380634174	5	116.0069167	770267.9833
2007	Burberry	18.3817	37.2764	0.828995157	39.45578231	5218	0.180601171	2139895	5.361001704	5.5	111.6675	804265.8667
2008	Burberry	19.6604	37.853	0.733149931	43.10518877	5660	0.169655463	2134571	5.57653118	2	104.3005833	827500.65
2009	Burberry	-1.33999	-2.78114	0.87746891	51.42489428	6208	-1.428595082	2035942	7.496819952	0.5	96.211	872708.9833
2010	Burberry	12.9698	26.027	1.195894779	39.88400994	5608	-0.058770625	2081411	7.864334514		95.24066667	918575.1708
2011	Burberry	19.6963	35.6222	1.164514318	36.09104539	6681	0.395871686	2105105	8.058810671		97.4485	921532.6292
2012	Burberry	19.7071	36.1018	1.195878016	37.1326004	7991	0.418038573	2136871	8.029569772		98.26058333	922708.975
2013	Burberry	17.5464	29.6525	1.09228039	24.66755319	8867	0.209960271	2175333	7.639081714		99.1825	930906.675
2014	Burberry	19.0746	33.3183	1.251385151	22.25165563	9698	0.442830188	2244827	6.313899165		99.67	967996.4292
2015	Burberry	17.6205	27.9201	1.545110193	14.19910438	10309	0.477380008	2294727	5.421034614		100.0000833	1004221.25
2016	Burberry	16.5268	23.4101	1.870500928	12.70281942	10181	0.527668077	2338825	4.932216814	0.25	100.1670833	984886.5792
2017	Burberry	14.2733	21.3602	2.005485755	11.09082342	9828	0.48226262	2400956	4.426258878	0.5	102.64025	1020655.533
2018	Burberry	15.0981	24.7051	2.043588352	18.79472429	9752	0.564196485	2434694	4.111748158	0.75	103.4864167	1017510.133
2019	Burberry	16.1973	26.0387	1.786439619	18.44520548	9862	0.494714556	2474245	3.843384323		102.5859167	1046110.417
2020	Burberry	6.3993	6.57766	1.69486653	131.2766656	9892	-0.905877272	2219474	4.486067911	0.1	101.16475	779661.3333
2021	Burberry	20.9139	17.5109	2.248292544	95.85817786	9234	0.350194043	2409815	4.63219928	0.25	101.4408333	882599.575
2022	Burberry	18.0821	17.6633	2.001243781	94.61996605	8979	0.118515863	2526428	3.810558761	3.5	108.2524	1008035.183
2023	Burberry	20.4913	22.1911	1.708082027	104.2235218	8868	0.094101617	2536460	4.042061125	5.25		1019320.925
2024	Burberry	12.9043	15.2407	1.070011669	124.610052	9169	-0.788074764	2564378	4.27032922	4.75		975072.4375
2025	Burberry	-2.68184	-2.84974	1.105310531	195.4397394	8701	-2.093356668		4.489618661	4.25		984073.475



year	brand	margin	roe	liquidity	gearing	employe	perf_index	gdp_millions_cvm	unemployment_rate	bank_rate_eoy	cpih_clothing_index_avg	retail_tcf_avg_weekly_thou
2016	Nobody's Child			0.32666447			-0.524617781	2338825	4.932216814	0.25	100.1670833	984886.5792
2017	Nobody's Child			0.071238638		23	-1.133602758	2400956	4.426258878	0.5	102.64025	1020655.533
2018	Nobody's Child			0.480111365		27	-0.15877047	2434694	4.111748158	0.75	103.4864167	1017510.133
2019	Nobody's Child			0.298508517			-0.591747062	2474245	3.843384323		102.5859167	1046110.417
2020	Nobody's Child			0.026165977		16	-1.241064768	2219474	4.486067911	0.1	101.16475	779661.3333
2021	Nobody's Child			0.401104657		20	-0.347137863	2409815	4.63219928	0.25	101.4408333	882599.575
2022	Nobody's C	-10.214	-32.6959	1.200730616	33.34610012	40	0.057734304	2526428	3.810558761	3.5	108.2524	1008035.183
2023	Nobody's C	0.28638	1.17614	1.067838677	91.54713811	65	0.244006015	2536460	4.042061125	5.25		1019320.925
2024	Nobody's C	2.53796	21.5963	1.047975522	78.0154748	87	0.697494856	2564378	4.27032922	4.75		975072.4375



year	brand	margin	roe	liquidity	gearing	employe	perf_index	gdp_millions_cvm	unemployment_rate	bank_rate_eoy	cpih_clothing_index_avg	retail_tcf_avg_weekly_thou
2005	Primark	11.9192	54.3433	0.043955445	178.2411325	9942	0.462456965	2036675	4.805842124	4.5	120.8728333	725177.5583
2006	Primark	10.568	46.7344	0.045422792	474.2483286	13144	-0.041203055	2085162	5.380634174	5	116.0069167	770267.9833
2007	Primark	4.91776	31.0603	0.047151728	579.4829476	18977	-0.743930094	2139895	5.361001704	5.5	111.6675	804265.8667
2008	Primark	1.87033	15.6926	0.062538191	745.1586899	20849	-1.226658766	2134571	5.57653118	2	104.3005833	827500.65
2009	Primark	2.94239	25.6842	0.044506396	683.5660595	21827	-1.083322858	2035942	7.496819952	0.5	96.211	872708.9833
2010	Primark	9.66418	71.3301	0.043853118	403.1945622	23707	0.179080089	2081411	7.864334514		95.24066667	918575.1708
2011	Primark	8.01661	74.4701	0.043780791	643.3023495	25575	-0.197092481	2105105	8.058810671		97.4485	921532.6292
2012	Primark	7.28942	71.6252	0.031108231	592.8115653	27965	-0.295419728	2136871	8.029569772		98.26058333	922708.975
2013	Primark	9.17924	73.0546	0.037211355	362.2612551	29753	0.164527058	2175333	7.639081714		99.1825	930906.675
2014	Primark	9.83228	85.0865	0.036313565	335.8915695	31350	0.34973792	2244827	6.313899165		99.67	967996.4292
2015	Primark	10.234	77.9193	0.052453555	259.5864581	31983	0.495328853	2294727	5.421034614		100.0000833	1004221.25
2016	Primark	10.3804	63.4255	0.075596605	287.1246346	33415	0.476621768	2338825	4.932216814	0.25	100.1670833	984886.5792
2017	Primark	9.59229	43.2761	0.074516257	157.9320462	35781	0.372709108	2400956	4.426258878	0.5	102.64025	1020655.533
2018	Primark	9.95455	33.8107	0.094280207	94.19516698	38046	0.500762971	2434694	4.111748158	0.75	103.4864167	1017510.133
2019	Primark	9.66442	26.5161	0.099036259	52.42723553	37313	0.481425521	2474245	3.843384323		102.5859167	1046110.417
2020	Primark	3.58391	3.97984	0.123731161	148.5516917	35757	-0.172275431	2219474	4.486067911	0.1	101.16475	779661.3333
2021	Primark	3.29606	3.43394	0.168673533	130.840543	32848	0.074271926	2409815	4.63219928	0.25	101.4408333	882599.575
2022	Primark	5.90743	8.37337	0.16900955	100.7530813	31819	0.363749443	2526428	3.810558761	3.5	108.2524	1008035.183
2023	Primark	3.66599	5.77933	0.158113143	90.87363478	7061	0.110469446	2536460	4.042061125	5.25		1019320.925
2024	Primark	3.8266	7.45121	0.090457499	114.3240154	33888	-0.271238652	2564378	4.27032922	4.75		975072.4375

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